

Integer Linear Forms for a Factorial Reciprocal Series

An integral basis and a finite gcd formula

WILL COOK*

31 August 2026; revised 30 September 2026

ABSTRACT

We classify the integer vectors that cancel prescribed initial weighted sums in linear forms $MS + k$, where $S = \sum_{n \geq 2} (n! - 1)^{-1}$. An integral basis reduces the support restriction to one linear Diophantine equation. The possible values of M are determined by a gcd over fewer than $2D^2$ indices when cancellation is imposed through D . For $D = 4$ we construct a vector with the least positive value $M = 1380$. Nonintegrality for a family with the required denominator divisibility remains open.

1 Introduction

Erdős asked whether replacing $n!$ by $n! - 1$ preserves the irrationality of the reciprocal sum [1, p. 102]. The question appears as Problem 68 in Bloom’s catalogue [2].

Problem 1.1 (Erdős Problem #68). Is

$$S = \sum_{n \geq 2} \frac{1}{n! - 1}$$

irrational?

The elementary proof that e is irrational uses two properties of factorials: they clear every earlier denominator, and they leave a small positive tail. The first property fails here. If $H_m = \sum_{n=2}^m (n! - 1)^{-1}$, then already $3!H_3 = 36/5$. We shall instead construct linear forms $MS + k$, with $M, k \in \mathbb{Z}$, in which several initial summands cancel. A non-integral form excludes every rational value $S = a/q$ for which $q \mid M$.

We solve the cancellation equations by constructing an integral basis whose vectors isolate the weighted sums (Theorem 2.1). We seek coefficient vectors supported on indices at least two. Allowing index one temporarily makes the basis construction triangular; setting that coefficient to zero then leaves a single linear Diophantine equation. Its solvability determines the possible values of M . Theorem 3.1 shows that the gcd in this equation can be computed on a finite interval.

**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

The starting identity is $n(n-1)! - n! = 0$. The corresponding weighted difference vanishes unless the floor exponent changes, that is, unless the weight index divides n . Subtracting the previously constructed vectors for the proper divisors leaves only the weighted sum at n . All these operations are integral, and both triangular changes of basis have diagonal entries 1 or -1 . Their inverses are therefore integral as well, which is why the construction gives every integer solution.

When V_2, V_3, V_4 vanish, the least positive value of M is 1380. We derive a vector attaining this value and bound its remainder between consecutive integers. The classification itself does not assume that S is rational. An irrationality proof would require, for each $q > 0$, a nonintegral form whose coefficient M is divisible by q . The companion constructs primitive vectors with this divisibility property; nonintegrality of their remainders remains unproved.

Hančl and Tijdeman's tail-integrality lemma treats factorial series with integer coefficients [4, Lemma 2.1 and the following remark, p. 385]. Their factorial-scaled partial sums are integers. For the partial sums H_m , the identity (1) below supplies the integer needed for the denominator argument. Koepf and Schmiersau's factorial-digit criterion [3, Example 3.2, p. 121] is used in the [companion's digit argument](#) to give an equivalent eventual-pattern condition for $S - e + 2$. Failure of that pattern at arbitrarily large indices also remains unproved.

Sections 2 and 3 give the coordinate construction and finite gcd. Section 4 uses them to construct and test a vector attaining the least positive value of M . Section 5 states the remaining nonintegrality question, with the secondary arithmetic criteria developed in the companion.

2 An integral basis

Since $d! \equiv 1 \pmod{d! - 1}$, dividing $n!$ by an integer power of $d!$ preserves its residue whenever the quotient is integral. We choose the exponent so that the quotient changes predictably at successive indices. For $d \geq 2$ and $n \geq 1$, put

$$W_{d,n} = \frac{n!}{(d!)^{\lfloor n/d \rfloor}}.$$

Writing $n = kd + r$, $0 \leq r < d$, shows that $W_{d,n}$ is $r!$ times the multinomial coefficient $n!/((d!)^k r!)$. In particular it is an integer, and $n! = (d!)^k W_{d,n}$ gives $W_{d,n} \equiv n! \pmod{d! - 1}$. For example, $W_{3,4} = 4$ and $(4! - W_{3,4})/(3! - 1) = 4$. The exponent $\lfloor n/d \rfloor$ increases precisely at multiples of d , which will determine the nonzero weighted differences.

For a finitely supported integer vector $\lambda = (\lambda_n)_{n \geq 1}$, define the integer linear forms

$$M(\lambda) = \sum_n \lambda_n n!, \quad V_d(\lambda) = \sum_n \lambda_n W_{d,n},$$

and let

$$\mathcal{R}(\lambda) = \sum_{d \geq 2} \frac{V_d(\lambda)}{d! - 1}.$$

Choose $N \geq 2$ beyond the support of λ . For $d > N$ the floor exponents are zero, so $V_d = M$ and the series converges absolutely. Only the first $N - 1$ terms can differ from

those of MS , and the weight congruence gives

$$\mathcal{R}(\lambda) - M(\lambda)S = \sum_{d=2}^N \frac{V_d(\lambda) - M(\lambda)}{d! - 1} \in \mathbb{Z}. \quad (1)$$

We now solve $V_2 = \dots = V_D = 0$ in integer vectors, allowing either sign of M . Write e_n for the unit vector at index n . The auxiliary coordinate at index one will make the basis triangular. It occurs only in the coefficient vector: the series still starts at $d = 2$, so no term $1/(1! - 1)$ is introduced. We impose $\lambda_1 = 0$ in Section 3.

The identity $n(n-1)! - n! = 0$ suggests starting with $T_n = ne_{n-1} - e_n$. At $n = 2$, the vector $U_2 = 2e_1 - e_2$ has $V_2 = 1$ and every other weighted sum zero. At $n = 4$, the difference $T_4 = 4e_3 - e_4$ has two nonzero weighted sums. One correction suffices:

Vector	M	V_2	V_3	V_4
T_4	0	6	0	23
$6U_2$	0	6	0	0
$T_4 - 6U_2$	0	0	0	23

For $d > 4$ these weighted sums equal $M = 0$. Thus $U_4 = T_4 - 6U_2$ isolates $V_4 = 4! - 1$. In general, the unwanted sums occur at proper divisors of n , whose correcting vectors are already available in an inductive construction.

Theorem 2.1 (an integer basis with prescribed weighted sums). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) *Set*

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$T_n = ne_{n-1} - e_n, \quad U_n = T_n - \sum_{\substack{d|n \\ 2 \leq d < n}} W_{d,n} U_d \quad (n \geq 2).$$

Then

$$M(U_n) = 0, \quad V_d(U_n) = (d! - 1)\mathbf{1}_{d=n}.$$

The vectors $e_1, U_2, U_3, \dots$ form an integral basis. Every finite vector has the unique finite expansion

$$\lambda = M(\lambda)e_1 + \sum_{d \geq 2} \frac{V_d(\lambda) - M(\lambda)}{d! - 1} U_d. \quad (2)$$

Proof. We have $M(T_n) = 0$. If $d \nmid n$, the floor exponents at $n-1$ and n agree, so $nW_{d,n-1} = W_{d,n}$. If $d \mid n$, the exponent increases by one, so $nW_{d,n-1} = d!W_{d,n}$. Hence

$$V_d(T_n) = (d! - 1)W_{d,n}\mathbf{1}_{d|n}.$$

Suppose the asserted identities hold below n . For each proper divisor d , subtracting $W_{d,n}U_d$ cancels the sum at d and changes none of the others. The sum at n remains $n! - 1$, since $W_{n,n} = 1$. This proves the identities by induction.

For completeness, restrict to indices $1, \dots, N$. The columns $e_1, T_2, \dots, T_N$ form a triangular integer matrix with diagonal $1, -1, \dots, -1$. Replacing each T_n by U_n subtracts an integer combination of earlier columns, so the second change of basis is triangular with

diagonal one. Both matrices have integer inverses: back-substitution divides only by 1 or -1 . Hence $e_1, U_2, \dots, U_N$ is a basis over $\mathbb{Z}$.

In the resulting expansion, applying M gives the coefficient of e_1 . If the coefficient of U_d is c_d , applying V_d gives $V_d = M + (d! - 1)c_d$, which proves (2). For $d > N$ that coefficient is zero because $V_d = M$. $\square$

For a prime $p \geq 3$ the divisor sum is empty, and $U_p = pe_{p-1} - e_p$. At a composite index the correction terms remove the extra weighted sums. For example,

$$U_9 = 9e_8 - e_9 - 5040e_2 + 1680e_3. \quad (3)$$

Since $M(U_n) = 0$ and $\mathcal{R}(U_n) = 1$, adding an integer multiple of U_n changes only V_n among the weighted sums and changes the remainder by an integer. It therefore preserves both M and the fractional part of the remainder.

3 Possible values of M

Fix $D \geq 2$. We first solve $V_2 = \dots = V_D = 0$ with index one allowed, and then impose the support restriction $\lambda_1 = 0$. The weight congruence, or the coordinates in (2), gives

$$V_d(\lambda) \equiv M(\lambda) \pmod{d! - 1}. \quad (4)$$

It follows that M must be divisible by

$$L_D = \text{lcm}_{2 \leq d \leq D}(d! - 1).$$

This necessary condition is sufficient while index one is allowed: L_De_1 has every weighted sum equal to L_D , and subtracting $L_D/(d! - 1)$ copies of U_d sets the d th sum to zero. Thus put

$$K_D = L_De_1 - \sum_{d=2}^D \frac{L_D}{d! - 1} U_d.$$

Uniqueness of the coordinates now gives the complete solution

$$V_2 = \dots = V_D = 0 \iff \lambda = tK_D + \sum_{n>D} z_n U_n, \quad M = tL_D, \quad (5)$$

with $t \in \mathbb{Z}$ and finitely many nonzero integers z_n . The lower coordinates are fixed by t ; all higher coordinates remain free. Since $\mathcal{R}(e_1) = S$ and $\mathcal{R}(U_n) = 1$, we also have

$$\mathcal{R}\left(tK_D + \sum_{n>D} z_n U_n\right) = tL_D(S - H_D) + \sum_{n>D} z_n, \quad H_D = \sum_{d=2}^D \frac{1}{d! - 1}. \quad (6)$$

It remains to remove index one. Write a_D for its coefficient in K_D , and u_n for its coefficient in U_n . All other coordinates already lie in the permitted range $n \geq 2$, so the only remaining equation is

$$ta_D + \sum_{n>D} z_n u_n = 0. \quad (7)$$

The higher corrections can change this coefficient by exactly the integer multiples of $g_D = \gcd\{u_n : n > D\}$. Thus the equation is soluble precisely when $g_D \mid ta_D$. For example, at depth four we shall find $a_4 = -55$ and $g_4 = 60$. Removing index one then requires $60 \mid 55t$, or $12 \mid t$; hence $M = 115t$ must be a multiple of 1380.

In general, the possible values of M form the ideal

$$\mu_D \mathbb{Z}, \quad \mu_D = L_D \frac{g_D}{\gcd(g_D, a_D)}. \quad (8)$$

Indeed, division by $\gcd(g_D, a_D)$ leaves two coprime integers, so $g_D \mid ta_D$ holds exactly when $g_D / \gcd(g_D, a_D) \mid t$. Bézout's identity supplies the required finite combination of the u_n . The next theorem proves $g_D > 0$ and bounds the indices needed for this combination. A vector attaining the least positive value μ_D is primitive, since dividing its coefficients by a common factor would give a smaller positive value of M .

3.1 A finite gcd calculation

The recursion for the first coordinate is

$$u_2 = 2, \quad u_n = - \sum_{\substack{d \mid n \\ 2 \leq d < n}} W_{d,n} u_d \quad (n > 2).$$

Induction gives $u_n = 0$ at odd indices. At twice a prime it gives $u_{2p} = -(2p)!/2^{p-1} \neq 0$, including $p = 2$, so the tail contains a nonzero coefficient and $g_D > 0$. To compute this infinite gcd, we show that a specified finite interval already forces divisibility of every later coefficient.

The induction has two cases. For a proper divisor $d > D$, divisibility comes from the earlier coefficient u_d . For $d \leq D$, it must instead come from the weight $W_{d,n}$. The following cutoff makes the second argument work for every such d .

Theorem 3.1 (a finite formula for the gcd). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) Choose a prime ℓ with $D/2 < \ell \leq D$ and put $H = D(2\ell - 1)$. Then

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$g_D = \gcd(u_{D+1}, \dots, u_H), \quad H < 2D^2.$$

Proof. Let $g = \gcd(u_{D+1}, \dots, u_H)$. The index 2ℓ belongs to this interval, and $u_{2\ell} = -(2\ell)!/2^{\ell-1} \neq 0$. Consequently $g > 0$ and $g \mid (2\ell)!$.

We prove $g \mid u_n$ for every $n > D$ by strong induction. This is true up to H by definition. For $n > H$, consider a proper divisor $d \geq 2$ in the recurrence for u_n . If $d > D$, the induction hypothesis gives $g \mid u_d$. If $d \leq D$, put $k = n/d$. The choice $H = D(2\ell - 1)$ ensures $k \geq 2\ell$. Moreover,

$$\frac{W_{d,n}}{k!} = \frac{n!}{(d!)^k k!} \in \mathbb{Z} :$$

this quotient counts partitions of n labelled objects into k unordered blocks of size d . Hence $(2\ell)! \mid k! \mid W_{d,n}$, so $g \mid W_{d,n}$ in the small-divisor case as well. Every product $W_{d,n}u_d$ in the recurrence is therefore divisible by g .

Thus g divides the whole tail. Conversely, every common divisor of the tail divides its finite subfamily $u_{D+1}, \dots, u_H$. The two gcds are equal, and $H \leq D(2D - 1) < 2D^2$. $\square$

Bertrand's postulate supplies the prime ℓ when $D \geq 3$; for $D = 2$ take $\ell = 2$. The proof requires $n/d \geq 2\ell$ for every small divisor, which is why it uses the cutoff $H = D(2\ell - 1)$. A truncation at $2D$ is not justified by this argument.

The finite gcd also gives a construction. Compute integers b_n with $\sum_{n=D+1}^H b_n u_n = g_D$ by the extended Euclidean algorithm, and put $h = \gcd(g_D, a_D)$. Taking

$$t = g_D/h, \quad z_n = -(a_D/h)b_n \quad (D < n \leq H)$$

makes $ta_D + \sum z_n u_n = 0$. Substitution in (5) therefore produces a vector with $M = \mu_D$. This gives an attaining vector as well as the minimum. Minimising its support or its coefficient norm is a separate problem.

4 An example attaining the minimum

At depth four the recursion gives

$$L_4 = 115, \quad K_4 = -55e_1 + 16e_2 + 3e_3 + 5e_4, \quad a_4 = -55.$$

Take $\ell = 3$ in Theorem 3.1, so that $H = 20$. The coefficients in this finite interval have gcd 60. There is a useful short proof: $u_6 = -180$, $u_8 = -4200$ and $23u_6 - u_8 = 60$, while

$$\text{lcm}(1, \dots, n) \mid u_n \tag{9}$$

gives the reverse divisibility for every $n > 4$. To prove (9), put $\Lambda_n = \text{lcm}(1, \dots, n)$. For a prime r , write v_r for its valuation. If $d \mid n$, Legendre's formula gives

$$v_r(W_{d,n}) = \sum_{j \geq 1} \left(\left\lfloor \frac{n}{r^j} \right\rfloor - \frac{n}{d} \left\lfloor \frac{d}{r^j} \right\rfloor \right) \geq v_r(\Lambda_n) - v_r(\Lambda_d).$$

Each summand is nonnegative, and each power $d < r^j \leq n$ contributes at least one. Hence $\Lambda_n \mid W_{d,n}\Lambda_d$, and induction in the recurrence, starting from $u_2 = 2$, proves the assertion. Formula (8) now gives

$$\mu_4 = 115 \frac{60}{\gcd(60, 55)} = 1380.$$

To attain $M = 1380$, take $t = 12$ in (7). The choice $z_6 = -27$, $z_8 = 1$ works because

$$12(-55) - 27(-180) - 4200 = 0.$$

The vector $12K_4 - 27U_6 + U_8$ therefore has no index-one coefficient and cancels V_2, V_3, V_4 . To remove its coefficients at indices four and seven, add $-26U_5 + 8U_7$. These corrections still cancel through four and do not restore index one, since $u_5 = u_7 = 0$. Thus

$$\lambda = 12K_4 - 26U_5 - 27U_6 + 8U_7 + U_8,$$

which expands to

$$\lambda = 1482e_2 - 784e_3 - 136e_5 + 83e_6 - e_8, \quad (M, V_2, V_3, V_4) = (1380, 0, 0, 0). \tag{10}$$

n	λ_n	$n!$	$W_{2,n}$	$W_{3,n}$	$W_{4,n}$
2	1482	2	1	2	2
3	-784	6	3	1	6
5	-136	120	30	20	5
6	83	720	90	20	30
8	-1	40320	2520	1120	70
Weighted totals		1380	0	0	0

Table 1: The depth-four vector and its checks. To obtain the last row, multiply each of the final four columns by λ_n before summing.

Table 1 verifies all four sums directly.

The coordinates already give $M = 1380$ and the three cancellations. They also determine the integer term in (6), namely $-26 - 27 + 8 + 1 = -44$. Thus

$$\mathcal{R}(\lambda) = 1380(S - H_4) - 44.$$

For the remainder estimate, the inequality $(n+1)! - 1 > (n+1)(n! - 1)$ gives the geometric bound

$$0 < S - H_N < \frac{N+2}{(N+1)((N+1)! - 1)} < \frac{2}{(N+1)! - 1} \quad (N \geq 2). \quad (11)$$

The majorant starts with $1/((N+1)! - 1)$ and has ratio $1/(N+2)$.

Exact rational arithmetic gives

$$-31 + \frac{4}{5} < 1380 \sum_{d=5}^8 \frac{1}{d! - 1} - 44 < -31 + \frac{5}{6}, \quad \frac{2 \cdot 1380}{9! - 1} < \frac{1}{100}.$$

The positive remaining tail is less than $2/(9! - 1)$, so $-31 < \mathcal{R}(\lambda) < -30$. If $S = a/q$ with $q \mid 1380$, (1) would make this remainder an integer. Every divisor of 1380 is therefore excluded.

The companion gives the [alternative dual congruence, support and coefficient-norm refinements](#). These minimise different quantities. The minimum of M follows from (8) and does not require minimal support.

5 Nonintegrality of the remainder

Fix a vector with $V_2 = \dots = V_D = 0$ and $M > 0$. We may choose the cutoff $N \geq D$ anywhere at or beyond its support. Separate the finite signed sum from the positive tail:

$$A_N = \sum_{d=D+1}^N \frac{V_d(\lambda)}{d! - 1}, \quad \mathcal{R}(\lambda) = A_N + M(S - H_N).$$

By (11), $0 < S - H_N < 2/((N + 1)! - 1)$. We can prove nonintegrality by comparing its upper bound with the distance from A_N to the next integer:

$$\frac{2M}{(N + 1)! - 1} < \lfloor A_N \rfloor + 1 - A_N. \quad (12)$$

Under this inequality, $\mathcal{R}(\lambda)$ lies strictly between consecutive integers, excluding every denominator dividing M . The argument allows either sign of A_N . Its strict gap is one when A_N is integral and can be arbitrarily small when A_N approaches an integer from below.

There are primitive solutions with $0 < M < N!$ for which M is eventually divisible by any prescribed q . The [progression construction in the companion](#) gives such a family by turning $V_d = 0$ into roots of a polynomial. At its support endpoint the omitted tail is less than $2/N$, but the gap on the right of (12) may shrink too. For each prescribed q , an irrationality proof requires a vector satisfying both this comparison and $q \mid M$. Unboundedness of M alone does not suffice. No minimal-support assertion is made for this family.

Increasing the cutoff is a different operation from choosing a new vector. For $-6e_2 + e_4$ the support ends at four, where the test fails because $9/115 < 24/119$. At $N = 5$ it succeeds because $13376/13685 > 24/719$. More generally, for a fixed vector with $M > 0$, the quantities A_N increase to $\mathcal{R}$. If this limit is nonintegral, their gaps to the next integer tend to a positive number, so the test eventually succeeds. If the limit is integral, the eventual gap equals the omitted tail and the test fails. Thus extending the cutoff eventually detects a nonintegral remainder, but leaves both the remainder and M unchanged.

Nor can a change of coefficients preserving M decide nonintegrality. By (1), the remainders of two vectors with the same value of M differ by an integer. Adding multiples of the U_n can therefore simplify the support and weighted sums, as in the example, without changing whether the remainder is integral.

The companion treats the [equivalent carry condition](#) and the [complementary-denominator tail inequality](#). It also records two larger finite computations: a non-unit carry at $m = 300000$ excludes every $q \mid 299999!$, and a continued-fraction enclosure excludes every $q < 2^{39990}$. Both computations were performed outside Lean; their [algorithms, exact outputs and scope](#) are given there. The factorial-divisibility exclusion does not exclude all denominators with only small prime factors, whose exponents may be larger. Neither finite restriction establishes the required condition at arbitrarily large indices.

6 Verification

Formal proofs. A result with a kernel-checked Lean proof carries links beside its heading and in the margin; both open the same evidence. *Lean* opens the proof: the declaration itself when one declaration states the whole result, otherwise the list of declarations that together state it. Inline citations to individual declarations elsewhere may identify ingredients of a proof. *Comparator* opens the recorded comparison, in which the same statement, written again from Mathlib alone in a separate repository, was compared

with our proof by Lean’s Comparator tool, allowing only the three standard axioms. *Comparator pending* means that the complete statement has no recorded comparison yet. A dagger on the Lean mark means that the Lean proof assumes an input named just below the result. A result without a mark has no Lean proof of its whole statement; what is checked is said below it. The [evidence record](#) gives every declaration, version and check. Comparator checks statements, axioms and kernel acceptance; it does not establish novelty or peer review. These checks show that the stated propositions are proved; whether they are the right propositions is a question the reader can settle by comparing them with the text.

The integral-basis theorem and finite gcd formula have recorded exact Lean bindings. The [companion source concordance](#) identifies their declarations and the theorem on the possible values of M . Its large finite computations are separate from these kernel proofs.

Acknowledgements

The author thanks Wouter van Doorn for advice on exposition: explaining notation when it first appears, avoiding private terminology, and saying how restrictive a conditional hypothesis is. His advice concerned the writing of another note; he has not reviewed the mathematics of this paper. An AI research pass supplied by Will Cook derived the depth-four dual congruence and shorter vectors from the weighted linear forms and the classification of their possible coefficients M developed earlier here. OpenAI Codex checked and integrated them; a separate AI pass reviewed the proof.

References

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- [4] Jaroslav Hančl and Robert Tijdeman. [On the irrationality of factorial series](#). *Acta Arithmetica* **118** (4) (2005), 383–401.